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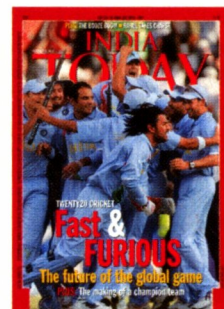
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I must admit I was a little sceptical when cricketers were sold like thoroughbreds at the IPL auction in January. For businessmen like Mukesh Ambani and Vijay Mallya and celebrities like Shah Rukh Khan and Preity Zinta, bidding for cricket franchises seemed more like acquiring a new hobby or a toy to play with than serious business. How wrong I was. It has turned out to be not just serious business but very serious play. The T20 format has transformed the way cricket is played and the Rs 9,000 crore extravaganza has revolutionised the business of cricket. IPL has everything that Indians love—Bollywood, cricket and money. No wonder millions watched these matches which even pulled in audiences like women who normally are not avid cricket watchers.

Corporatisation was the shot in the arm the game clearly needed. The franchise owners spent a total of \$723 million to acquire their teams which means an average of around \$90 million per team. It was the birth of a billion dollar baby. Cricket had never seen such sums. Nor had cricketers. Top players of IPL will earn between Rs 1 and 2 crore per season. Many of them will be in a league similar to the millionaire footballers in Europe and England. The prize money for the winning team of IPL is \$1.2 million. In contrast, the winners of World T20 in the Caribbean got a mere \$0.49 million. Television rights of IPL have already been sold for over \$1 billion.

More than the money it was the logistics which took cricket to a new level. Eight teams, 128 players and 59 matches in 44 days at multiple venues involved a mammoth logistical challenge. IPL is bigger—in terms of sheer logistical activity—than the ICC World Cup, the Commonwealth Games and the Asian Games. The League had booked 12,000 hotel nights, 20,000 air tickets and had the huge task of ferrying some 1,000 people, including the teams, every day from one part of India to another. That this was done without a hitch and in the face of a serial bomb blast in Jaipur, one of the venues, is truly amazing for India where every solution generally has 10 problems. The purists might accuse the BCCI of crass commercialisation of cricket, but anything so radical will always invite such fears. Our cover story takes an inside look at the way the IPL was put together, the challenges and logistics, the workings of a gigantic money machine, the emergence of new stars, how it will impact traditional cricket, and some genuine problems it could face in future.

Personally, I was excited by the greats of international cricket playing with Indian youngsters and teaching them the finer points of the game. Also, bitter opponents of international cricket playing on the same side and supporting each other. I feel all this will have a very positive and far reaching impact on the game. Twenty cheers for IPL!



Our Oct 2007 cover

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